



USC University of
Southern California

Course Title: **The Eastern European Jewish Experience through Literature and Film**

Units: 4

Instructors:

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Office hours: by appointment

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Course Description:

For centuries, Eastern Europe has been home to the world's largest Jewish population. The traditions, art, and historical experience of the Eastern European diaspora have been a fundamental source of influence for contemporary hubs of Jewish Life, the United States and Israel. In our class, we will analyze works by different artists – writers, filmmakers, painters – in order to grasp to what extent the Jewish experience in Eastern Europe may be considered either unique or representative of Jewish communities worldwide. We will discuss concepts such as exile, diaspora, assimilation, Jewish socialism, and Zionism; engage with literary responses to antisemitism and the Holocaust; and compare Jewish literatures in multiple countries. We will look at writers for whom Jewishness was a crucial element of their identity and those who were

trying to hide it. We will compare the reception their works enjoyed among the Jewish and non-Jewish audiences.

The materials covered in the class may contain potentially offensive and disturbing content.

Learning Objectives:

The main goal of the course is to introduce students to the rich world of Eastern European Jewish culture. Students will learn about Eastern Europe as a multicultural space where Jewish communities were exposed to various influences and political dynamics. For students of Jewish heritage, the course will offer an opportunity to explore their identity and look at it as a multilayered product of historical developments. Students interested in Eastern Europe in general will have a chance to explore its cultures through lenses different than those dominated by the hegemonic narratives of Russian or Polish literatures, and investigate the tensions between majority and minority cultures. Moreover, students will be able to see how a case study of Jewish Literature in Eastern Europe can be used in more general analyses of issues such as multiculturalism, assimilation, diaspora, global citizenship, ethnic conflict, genocide, migration, all extremely relevant in today's globalized world.

Class Policies

Attendance in all classes is mandatory; after two unexcused absences, the student is at risk of failing the class. Phone, laptop, tablet, and any electronic device use in class is strictly prohibited unless specified otherwise by the instructor. If you are caught using a phone during class two times, you might fail the class. You must bring a physical copy of the book we discuss that week. If you don't have the book with you more than two times, you might fail the class. You don't have to print texts that are uploaded on Brightspace.

Use of AI in any shape or form is strictly prohibited in this course.

Communication

Electronic Communication:

Students are required to check their USC e-mail daily.

Policy for Missed or Late Work:

All assignments are to be turned in on time.

Description and Assessment of Assignments

- Weekly Quizzes

Each Tuesday, at the beginning of each instructional week, students will be given a quiz on the content of the reading/viewing. 10 closed-ended questions, **quiz to be taken on a phone or laptop.**

- Midterm Quiz

On Thursday of the 7th instructional week, students will take a midterm exam devoted to the socio-historical contexts in which the Eastern European Jewish literature covered in class arose and theoretical concepts related to it. The test will have a closed-ended, quiz format. All the questions will refer directly to the topics covered in class, 20 questions.

- Midterm Oral Exam

During the 8th instructional week, each student will deliver a 15-minute oral presentation on a quote from any of the readings covered so far. The presentation has to cover: 1. A thesis: what do you want to prove by selecting the quote? 2. Formal literary devices, in the context of the thesis. 3. Role of the quote in the larger context of a book. 4. Historical/Philosophical background of the quote. After the presentation, 5. the instructor will ask challenging follow-up questions about the quote and the book as a whole, and the student has to prepare to defend their position and interpretation. 6. The presentation has to be delivered according to the high standards of public speaking: no repetitions, confident voice, no filler words, appropriate cadence and rhythm. 10 points available for satisfying each item. 60-points maximum.

- Final Quiz

Same format as the Midterm exam covering the second part of the semester.

- Final Oral Exam

During the last instructional week, each student will deliver a 15-minute oral presentation on a topic of: 1. Love, 2. Tradition, 3. Jewishness, 4. Violence, 5. Humor as reflected in three self-selected readings covered in the class. The student has to thoroughly explain 1. how the readings address the problem, both formally and content-wise (specific examples), 2. what differences and similarities there are between them, 3. What general conclusion can be drawn

from said comparison, and how do the readings shine a new light on the theoretical problem? After the presentation, 4. the instructor will ask challenging follow-up questions, and the student has to prepare to defend their position and interpretation. 5. The presentation has to be delivered according to the high standards of public speaking: no repetitions, confident voice, no filler words, appropriate cadence and rhythm. 10 points available for satisfying each item. 50 points maximum.

Grading breakdown template

Assignment	% of Grade
Weekly Quizzes	30
Midterm Quiz	15
Midterm Oral Exam	20
Final Quiz	15
Final Oral Exam	20

Grading Scale (the lowest and highest two percentages within the grade receive + or -)

A – 90 – 100%

B – 80 – 89%

C – 70 – 79%

D – 60 – 69%

F – Below 60%

Assignment Submission

All assignments are to be uploaded to the course Blackboard page

Grading Timeline

All quizzes and tests will be graded automatically. Oral exams will be graded immediately.

Classroom Norms

Students are expected to exhibit mutual respect and act in the spirit of teamwork.

Sharing of course materials outside of the learning environment

SCampus Section 11.12(B)

Distribution or use of notes or recordings based on university classes or lectures without the express permission of the instructor for purposes other than individual or group study is a violation of the USC Student Conduct Code. This includes, but is not limited to, providing materials for distribution by services publishing class notes. This restriction on unauthorized use also applies to all information, which had been distributed to students or in any way had been displayed for use in relationship to the class, whether obtained in class, via email, on the Internet or via any other media. (See Section C.1 Class Notes Policy).

Course evaluation

Students are encouraged to submit evaluation forms in the middle of the semester and by the end of it.

Readings: same reading for Tuesday, Thursday, and Friday.

Week 1. Eastern European Jewish Experience: Historical Introduction

(Text on Brightspace)

Antony Polonsky, *Jews in Poland and Russia: A Short History* (Excerpt).

Week 2. Small Town Jewish Life

Sholem Aleichem, *Tevye the Dairyman and Motl the Cantor's Son*, pp. 1-135

Week 3. Tradition vs Modernity

Sholem Aleichem, *Tevye the Dairyman and Motl the Cantor's Son*, pp. 135-235

Week 4. Jewish Emigration

Sholem Aleichem, *Tevye the Dairyman and Motl the Cantor's Son*, pp. 235-281

Week 5. Americanization

Sholem Aleichem, *Tevye the Dairyman and Motl the Cantor's Son*, pp. 281-375

Week 6. Jewish Criminal Underground

Issac Babel, *Odessa Stories*, pp. 1-103

Week 7. Jewish Childhood

Isaac Babel, *Odessa Stories*, pp. 103-175

Week 8. Holocaust and the Problem of Its Representation

Film: *Unzere Kinder*, dir. Natan Gross.

Week 9. Holocaust Literature: Characteristics

Imre Kertesz, *Fatelessness*, pp. 1-99

Week 10. Irony in Holocaust Literature

Imre Kertesz, *Fatelessness*, pp. 99-189

Week 11. Testimony as a Genre. Ethics and Poetics.

Imre Kertesz, *Fatelessness*, pp. 189- 262

Film: *Everything is Illuminated*, dir. Liev Schreiber

Week 12. Jewish American Literature

Gary Shteyngart, *Super Sad True Love Story*, pp. 1- 98

Week 13. Eastern European Influence on Contemporary Jewish Identity in America

Gary Shteyngart, *Super Sad True Love Story*, pp. 98-203

Week 14. Jewishness and Postmodernism

Gary Shteyngart, *Super Sad True Love Story*, pp. 203- 330

Week 14. Jews and Money

Film: *Uncut Gems*, dir. Safdie Brothers

Academic Conduct:

Plagiarism – presenting someone else’s ideas as your own, either verbatim or recast in your own words – is a serious academic offense with serious consequences. Please familiarize yourself with the discussion of plagiarism in SCampus in Part B, Section 11, “Behavior Violating University Standards” policy.usc.edu/scampus-part-b. Other forms of academic dishonesty are equally unacceptable. See additional information in SCampus and university policies on Research and Scholarship Misconduct.

Students and Disability Accommodations:

USC welcomes students with disabilities into all of the University's educational programs. The Office of Student Accessibility Services (OSAS) is responsible for the determination of appropriate accommodations for students who encounter disability-related barriers. Once a student has completed the OSAS process (registration, initial appointment, and submitted documentation) and accommodations are determined to be reasonable and appropriate, a Letter of Accommodation (LOA) will be available to generate for each course. The LOA must be given to each course instructor by the student and followed up with a discussion. This should be done as early in the semester as possible as accommodations are not retroactive. More information can be found at osas.usc.edu. You may contact OSAS at (213) 740-0776 or via email at osasfrontdesk@usc.edu.

Support Systems:**Counseling and Mental Health - (213) 740-9355 – 24/7 on call**

studenthealth.usc.edu/counseling

Free and confidential mental health treatment for students, including short-term psychotherapy, group counseling, stress fitness workshops, and crisis intervention.

National Suicide Prevention Lifeline - 1 (800) 273-8255 – 24/7 on call

suicidepreventionlifeline.org

Free and confidential emotional support to people in suicidal crisis or emotional distress 24 hours a day, 7 days a week.

Relationship and Sexual Violence Prevention Services (RSVP) - (213) 740-9355(WELL),
press “0” after hours – 24/7 on call

studenthealth.usc.edu/sexual-assault

Free and confidential therapy services, workshops, and training for situations related to gender-based harm.

Office for Equity, Equal Opportunity, and Title IX (EEO-TIX) - (213) 740-5086

eeotix.usc.edu

Information about how to get help or help someone affected by harassment or discrimination, rights of protected classes, reporting options, and additional resources for students, faculty, staff, visitors, and applicants.

Reporting Incidents of Bias or Harassment - (213) 740-5086 or (213) 821-8298

usc-advocate.symplicity.com/care_report

Avenue to report incidents of bias, hate crimes, and microaggressions to the Office for Equity, Equal Opportunity, and Title for appropriate investigation, supportive measures, and response.

The Office of Student Accessibility Services (OSAS) - (213) 740-0776

osas.usc.edu

OSAS ensures equal access for students with disabilities through providing academic accommodations and auxiliary aids in accordance with federal laws and university policy.

USC Campus Support and Intervention - (213) 821-4710

campussupport.usc.edu

Assists students and families in resolving complex personal, financial, and academic issues adversely affecting their success as a student.

Diversity, Equity and Inclusion - (213) 740-2101

diversity.usc.edu

Information on events, programs and training, the Provost's Diversity and Inclusion Council, Diversity Liaisons for each academic school, chronology, participation, and various resources for students.

USC Emergency - UPC: (213) 740-4321, HSC: (323) 442-1000 – 24/7 on call

dps.usc.edu, emergency.usc.edu

Emergency assistance and avenue to report a crime. Latest updates regarding safety, including ways in which instruction will be continued if an officially declared emergency makes travel to campus infeasible.

USC Department of Public Safety - UPC: (213) 740-6000, HSC: (323) 442-120 – 24/7 on call

dps.usc.edu

Non-emergency assistance or information.

Office of the Ombuds - (213) 821-9556 (UPC) / (323) 442-0382 (HSC)

ombuds.usc.edu

A safe and confidential place to share your USC-related issues with a University Ombuds who will work with you to explore options or paths to manage your concern.

Occupational Therapy Faculty Practice - (323) 442-3340 or otfp@med.usc.edu

chan.usc.edu/otfp

Confidential Lifestyle Redesign services for USC students to support health promoting habits and routines that enhance quality of life and academic performance.